LARSON CAPITAL RESEARCH · AUGUST 2026

A quantified prediction of America's emerging rental markets, built by synthesizing public data.

The 110 largest US rental markets, ranked by the fundamentals that historically precede rent growth.

A validated 2025→2028 outlook and a speculative 2026→2029 view, built entirely on free public data.

Frozen · August 2026

Graded · early 2029
scored against realized rent growth

0.43
POOLED TAU ON FINALIZED DATA
RANDOM GUESSING SCORES ABOUT 0

+6.0 pp
TOP-10 EDGE PER COMPLETED WINDOW

110
MARKETS RANKED

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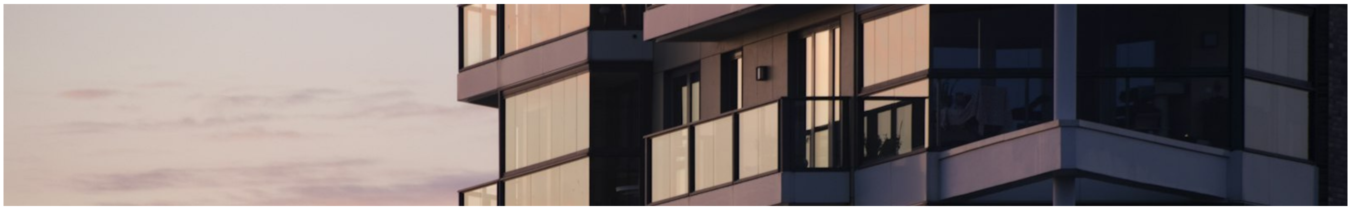
Model v2.0.0
A research screen, not investment advice



MULTIFAMILY RESEARCH · THE METHOD

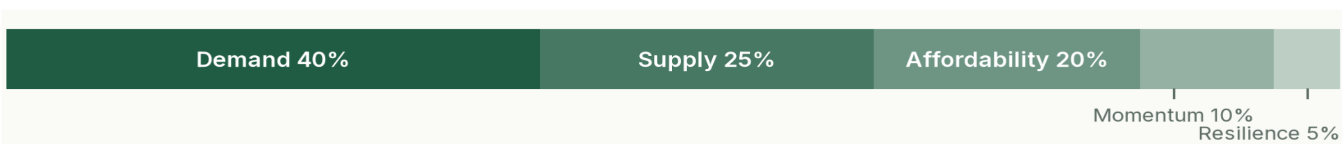
How it works

The screen ranks every US metro area over 500,000 people with continuous rent data on eight measures of fundamentals that historically come before strong rent growth. Each measure is compared across markets within the same year (so nationwide swings cancel out), weighted by a fixed published share, and summed into one score. The same formula runs for every market; no market is ever hand-adjusted; the weights are set by judgment.

Free public data — Census, BLS, BEA, Zillow → **Eight measures** — grouped in five themes → **Same-year comparison** — 0 = the average market → **Fixed public weights** — summed into one score → **Rank and tier** — with a 90% rank range

How the score is built, in five steps.

The five themes



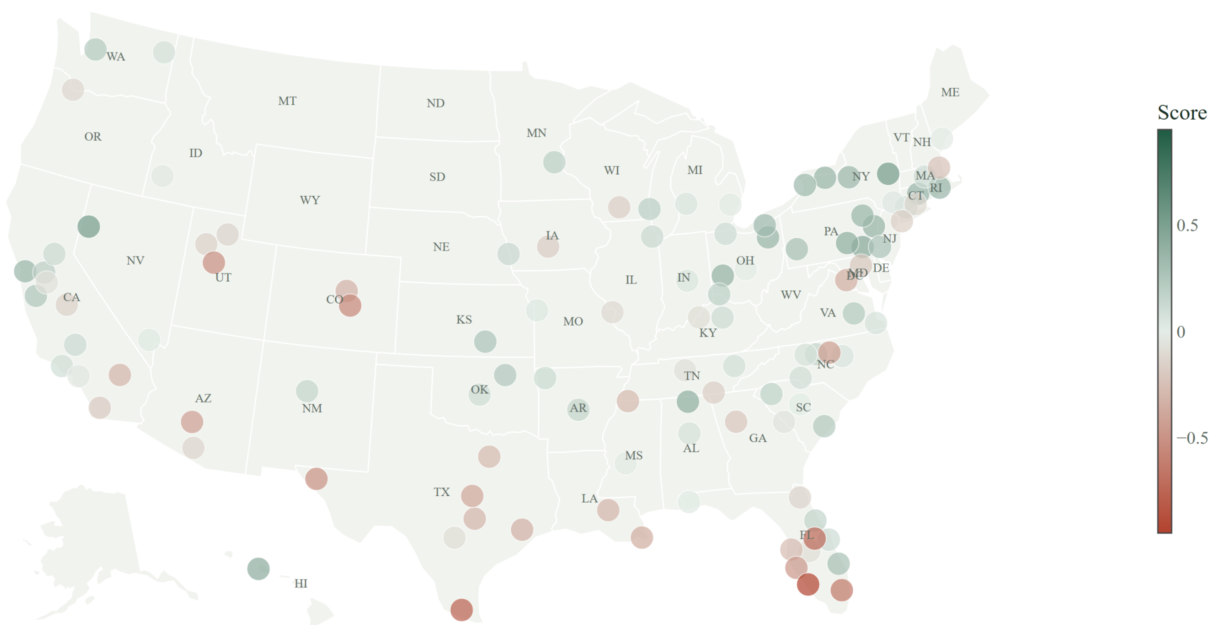
Theme	Weight	The idea
Demand	40%	Net migration, job growth, and income growth. Markets that people and paychecks are moving into fill apartments first; migration is the screen’s biggest bet.
Supply	25%	Building permits relative to existing housing, counted the opposite way: today’s construction is tomorrow’s competition.
Affordability	20%	Rent as a share of local income, and the cost of owning versus renting; when buying is far pricier, households stay renters longer.
Momentum	10%	Recent rent growth, deliberately held to a small weight: it decays and inverted badly in the 2020–22 shock.
Resilience	5%	Employment spread across industries; a one-sector economy carries more downside risk to rents.

MULTIFAMILY RESEARCH · THE REPORT

Key findings

What the screen says right now: the 110 largest US rental markets, ranked by fundamentals that have historically come before strong rent growth.

- **Albany-Schenectady-Troy leads the current screen**, lifted most by little new building and strong migration & jobs; its 90% rank range is 1–27.
- **The screen's top-10 markets out-grew the median market by +6.0 points of rent growth** across six completed windows; picking on recent rent growth alone earned +4.8.



Green = above the average market (score 0), clay = below; the tiers group markets the data cannot separate. Albany leads; Reno and Lancaster round out the top three. The 2025→2028 outlook.

The top 10

Rank	Metro	What lifts it most
1 (1–27)	Albany-Schenectady-Troy, NY	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
2 (1–28)	Reno, NV	Strong migration & jobs · Room for rents to grow
3 (2–37)	Lancaster, PA	Little new building · Room for rents to grow
4 (12–76)	Urban Honolulu, HI	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
5 (1–32)	Harrisburg-Carlisle, PA	Little new building · Rents climbing
6 (4–48)	Huntsville, AL	Strong migration & jobs · Room for rents to grow
7 (2–38)	Dayton-Kettering-Beavercreek, OH	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
8 (5–59)	Allentown-Bethlehem-Easton, PA-NJ	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
9 (2–42)	Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford, CT	Little new building · Rents climbing
10 (2–45)	Rochester, NY	Little new building · Rents climbing

Rank (90% range: where the rank lands 90% of the time once measurement noise is accounted for) and the themes lifting each score most.

Why Albany-Schenectady-Troy leads

Strongest on limited new supply (+0.24) and demand (migration & jobs) (+0.12) (contribution to its score). Its rents have out-grown the national median for 31 consecutive months. A #1 rank is a screening result, not a verdict.

The full measure-by-measure case for Albany-Schenectady-Troy, and for every other market, is on the companion site.

MULTIFAMILY RESEARCH · THE FINE PRINT

Track record

Every published run is frozen with its scores, rankings, inputs, and settings, and never edited; the complete record, including the failures, is published. **The frozen 2025→2028 screen will be scored against realized rent growth when 2028 rent data closes (early 2029), whatever it shows.**

The edge, in points of rent growth

Window start	This screen	Rent momentum	Equal weight	Random
2016	+7.2	+7.2	+5.9	+0.5
2017	+7.2	+6.2	+4.9	+0.3
2018	+10.4	+10.4	+6.3	+0.7
2019	+12.8	+10.6	+8.9	+0.5
2021	+0.0	-1.5	-2.9	-0.1
2022	-1.7	-4.3	-4.3	-0.4

Percentage points of 3-year rent growth above the median market for each strategy's top-10; each call is frozen at publication and graded three years later. Pooled, this screen earned +6.0 points (momentum +4.8); in the 2020–22 shock rows momentum flipped firmly negative while the screen held near flat. Rent data through July 2026.

Honest limits

- The rent data measures asking rents, not signed leases; where free-month move-in deals are common, asking rents understate the true decline (one oversupplied market in mid-2026: asking rents down about 2.6%, net of those deals about 7.2%).
- No capital-markets or operating-cost data (sale prices, cap rates, insurance, taxes); rent growth stands in for profitability, and Florida's 2023–26 insurance-cost shock shows what that misses.
- Measure weights are set by judgment and tested, not statistically fitted.
- The supply measure reads permit levels in the scoring year, so sharp turns in construction can show up with a lag.
- In shock periods like 2020–22 the screen loses most of its edge; treat it as a screen, not a forecast.

THE COMPANION SITE

This report is the snapshot

The interactive site is the working product. On it:

- All 110 markets, ranked, tiered, and mapped, with each market's 90% rank range and its move versus the prior frozen edition.
- A detail page for every market: its score, the themes driving it, and each measure in plain terms, with side-by-side comparison.
- A 2026→2029 outlook built on data through May 2026, labeled speculative throughout: that configuration failed validation.
- The full track record: every graded window, the interim reads on the newer calls, and the frozen registry of every published run.
- The data behind each measure, its source and vintage, and the boundary corrections that rebuilt it.

About the author

My name is **Ben Larson**, and I am a junior at **Indiana University** studying economics and applied math. My research interests center on quantitative market selection: applying data to identify optimal real estate markets across the U.S. and to help inform investment decisions across commercial real estate asset classes, including multifamily, industrial, retail, office, and data centers.

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